

Robust, Explainable, and Drift-Aware Hybrid Machine Learning Framework for Enterprise Network Intrusion Detection with Stacking Ensembles and Automated SOC Orchestration

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Abstract—Modern Security Operations Centers (SOCs) face escalating operational challenges driven by high-volume network traffic, sophisticated zero-day cyber threats, adversarial evasion attacks, severe class imbalance in rare intrusion vectors, and persistent alert fatigue stemming from legacy rule-based Intrusion Detection Systems (IDS). In this paper, we propose, implement, and evaluate an enterprise-grade, drift-aware, and explainable hybrid Machine Learning (ML) Network Intrusion Detection System (NIDS) trained on benchmark cybersecurity flow datasets including CICIDS2017. The proposed architecture introduces a dual-stage detection pipeline combining an unsupervised Isolation Forest model for zero-day anomaly isolation with a multi-model Stacking Meta-Ensemble Classifier combining Extreme Gradient Boosting (XGBoost), Random Forest (RF), Extra Trees (ET), and Histogram Gradient Boosting (HistGB) orchestrated via a Logistic Regression meta-learner. To address critical limitations identified in prior NIDS literature, our framework incorporates five novel technical capabilities: (1) SMOTE-Tomek Synthetic Class Rebalancing to resolve minority class imbalance in rare attack vectors (e.g., Web Attacks, Botnets, Infiltration); (2) TreeSHAP (SHapley Additive exPlanations) for local and global feature attribution interpretability; (3) an Adversarial Robustness & Evasion Defense Subsystem that generates synthetic feature perturbations (packet timing jitter and payload byte padding) to harden decision boundaries against evasion tactics; (4) a Kolmogorov-Smirnov (KS) & Page-Hinkley Concept Drift Monitor to track non-stationary stream distribution shifts; and (5) a Production SOC Incident Orchestration Layer backed by SQLite (`incidents.db`), an interactive Streamlit SOC dashboard, and ReportLab PDF executive audit report generation. Empirical evaluation demonstrates an overall classification accuracy of 99.64%, a weighted F1-score of 0.9961, a minority-class F1-score improvement of +14.8%, an adversarial evasion accuracy retention of 94.2% under 10% feature jitter, and an end-to-end processing latency of 1.66 milliseconds per flow record.

Index Terms—Network Intrusion Detection System (NIDS), Stacking Meta-Ensemble, Hybrid Machine Learning, Isolation Forest, XGBoost, Explainable AI (XAI), SHAP, Class Imbalance, SMOTE, Adversarial Evasion, Concept Drift, Kolmogorov-Smirnov Test, Security Operations Center (SOC), CICIDS2017.

I. INTRODUCTION & PROBLEM MOTIVATION

A. Context and Modern Enterprise Infrastructure Challenges

The rapid transformation of enterprise digital infrastructure into hybrid multi-cloud environments, containerized microservice clusters, and remote workforce networks has fundamentally redefined modern network perimeters. Contemporary enterprise backbones routinely process multi-gigabit flow throughput per second, generating tens of millions of bidirectional network flow records per hour. Within this high-velocity traffic environment, Security Operations Centers (SOCs) bear the responsibility of safeguarding sensitive corporate assets, intellectual property, and infrastructure against an increasingly sophisticated landscape of cyber threats.

Network Intrusion Detection Systems (NIDS) serve as the primary defensive barrier for monitoring network telemetry, identifying suspicious packet patterns, and triggering automated or analyst-guided incident response workflows. However, as cyber threat actors adopt automated exploitation frameworks, polymorphic malware, encrypted command-and-control (C2) channels, and distributed denial-of-service (DDoS) botnets, traditional intrusion detection paradigms struggle to maintain adequate defensive coverage.

B. Fundamentals of Signature-Based NIDS and Operational Limitations

Historically, enterprise NIDS deployments have been dominated by deterministic, signature-based detection engines such as Snort, Suricata, and Bro/Zeek [7]. These traditional engines operate by comparing packet headers and unencrypted payload strings against static databases of known attack signatures authored by security researchers. While signature-based engines exhibit near-zero false positive rates for known, static exploits, they suffer from fundamental architectural limitations:

- 1) **Inability to Detect Zero-Day Threats:** Signature engines are completely blind to novel zero-day exploits, unpatched vulnerabilities, and customized malware variants that lack pre-existing signature rules in the threat intelligence repository.

- 2) **Exponential Rule Maintenance Overhead:** Maintaining effective signature rules across massive corporate networks requires continuous manual rule authoring, testing, and tuning. Rule repositories frequently grow to tens of thousands of signatures, leading to high CPU overhead and processing bottlenecks.
- 3) **Severe Alert Fatigue:** Minor network configuration changes or benign protocol anomalies frequently trigger high volumes of false positive alerts. SOC analysts are routinely inundated with thousands of daily unprioritized alerts—a phenomenon known as *alert fatigue*—which leads to analyst burnout and delayed response times during genuine intrusion incidents [9].

C. Machine Learning in NIDS and The Operational Gap

To transcend the boundaries of static signatures, researchers have applied Machine Learning (ML) and Deep Learning (DL) techniques to network traffic analysis [1]. Supervised algorithms (such as Decision Trees, Random Forests, Support Vector Machines, and Convolutional Neural Networks) learn statistical flow distributions from labeled training datasets, achieving high empirical detection accuracy on benchmark datasets such as CICIDS2017 and UNSW-NB15 [8]. Unsupervised algorithms (such as Isolation Forests, One-Class SVMs, and Autoencoders) construct baseline models of benign behavior, flagging statistical outliers without requiring prior attack labels [2].

However, a comprehensive critique of existing academic NIDS literature reveals five major operational gaps that prevent theoretical ML models from transitioning into production-grade SOC environments:

- 1) **The Black-Box Interpretability Deficit:** Complex ensemble models (e.g., XGBoost, Stacking Classifiers) and Deep Learning networks operate as opaque black boxes. When a flow is flagged as malicious, the model fails to explain *why* the classification was made. SOC analysts cannot determine whether an alert was triggered by anomalous packet lengths, suspicious TCP flags, or abnormal throughput, leading analysts to distrust or discount ML-generated alerts.
- 2) **Severe Class Imbalance Neglect:** Real-world enterprise traffic is overwhelmingly dominated by benign flow packets (> 90%), whereas critical attack vectors such as Web Attacks (SQL Injection, Cross-Site Scripting), Botnets, and Infiltration account for less than 1% of total flow volume. Standard ML algorithms suffer from majority-class bias, achieving deceptively high overall accuracy while consistently failing to detect rare, high-impact intrusion attempts.
- 3) **Vulnerability to Adversarial Evasion Attacks:** Sophisticated cyber adversaries actively employ adversarial evasion techniques (e.g., injecting dummy payload bytes, altering inter-packet arrival times, or fragmenting TCP segments) to subtly alter flow features. Conventional ML classifiers degrade catastrophically when

subjected to perturbed flow data, as their rigid decision boundaries fail to account for adversarial noise [17].

- 4) **Non-Stationary Concept Drift:** Network flow distributions are intrinsically non-stationary. Corporate traffic patterns continuously evolve due to software deployment cycles, cloud migrations, user behavior shifts, and protocol updates. Existing NIDS models assume static data distributions and suffer severe performance degradation over time as concept drift accumulates without automated detection mechanisms [18].
- 5) **Absence of End-to-End SOC Orchestration:** Academic literature focuses almost exclusively on isolated offline classification metrics (Accuracy, Precision, Recall), neglecting the full operational lifecycle: dynamic multi-factor risk math, ACID-compliant database incident logging, automated security playbook recommendations, and executive PDF audit reporting.

D. Technical Contributions and Paper Organization

To systematically resolve these five operational gaps, this paper presents an enterprise-ready, explainable, and drift-aware hybrid NIDS framework. The primary technical contributions of this work are summarized below:

- **Dual-Stage Hybrid Architecture:** Integration of an unsupervised Isolation Forest model (for zero-day anomaly detection) with a multi-model Stacking Meta-Ensemble Classifier (XGBoost, Random Forest, Extra Trees, and Histogram Gradient Boosting orchestrated by a Logistic Regression meta-learner) for robust handling of novel anomalies and known attack classes (`src/classifier.py`).
- **SMOTE-Tomek Synthetic Class Rebalancing:** Implementation of SMOTE oversampling combined with Tomek Links cleanup (`src/preprocessing.py`) to eliminate majority-class bias and improve minority attack F1-scores by **+14.8%**.
- **Model Interpretability via TreeSHAP:** Full integration of game-theoretic TreeSHAP (`src/explainability.py`) to compute local and global feature attribution values, delivering waterfall and force plots for analyst verification.
- **Adversarial Perturbation & Evasion Defense:** Development of an adversarial testing harness (`src/adversarial.py`) that evaluates model decay under feature jitter and payload padding, establishing hardened decision boundaries that maintain **94.2%** accuracy under 10% feature perturbation noise.
- **Statistical Concept Drift Monitoring:** Implementation of two-sample Kolmogorov-Smirnov (KS) testing and Page-Hinkley cumulative sum testing (`src/drift.py`) to track stream feature distribution shifts and trigger automated retrain alerts.
- **Dynamic Composite Risk Math:** Formulation of an objective mathematical risk index $R(x) \in [0.0, 1.0]$ combining anomaly confidence, classification

probability, and static asset vulnerability weights (`src/recommendations.py`).

- **Production SOC Orchestration & Reporting:** Full integration with an SQLite database (`incidents.db`, `src/database.py`), an interactive Streamlit SOC dashboard (`app.py`, `dashboard/`), and ReportLab PDF report generation (`src/report_generator.py`).

The remainder of this paper is organized as follows: Section II surveys related work and establishes a systematic literature gap taxonomy. Section III details the proposed system architecture. Section IV describes data preprocessing and the canonical 22-feature schema. Section V presents the mathematical formulations and algorithmic innovations. Section VI provides detailed attack narratives for all threat vectors. Section VII presents comprehensive experimental results and benchmarks. Section VIII details SOC database integration and playbook automation. Section IX discusses operational trade-offs and threats to validity. Section X outlines future research directions, and Section XI concludes the paper.

II. COMPREHENSIVE LITERATURE SURVEY & GAP ANALYSIS

A. Evolution of Intrusion Detection Systems

Research in Network Intrusion Detection has evolved through three major paradigms over the past three decades:

- 1) **Signature-Based Systems:** Early engines like Snort [7] and Suricata pioneered protocol decoding and string-matching rule sets. While deterministic and computationally fast (< 0.1 ms per packet), signature engines cannot identify zero-day attacks or polymorphic evasion traffic.
- 2) **Classic Machine Learning Models:** The release of benchmark datasets such as KDD Cup 99, NSL-KDD, and UNSW-NB15 [8] prompted researchers to explore Decision Trees, Support Vector Machines (SVM), Naive Bayes, and Random Forests. Sharafaldin et al. [1] introduced the CICIDS2017 dataset, demonstrating that ensemble tree models achieve superior classification accuracy on raw flow metadata. Liu et al. [2] introduced Isolation Forest, proving that recursive random partitioning isolates anomalies with linear time complexity $O(n \log n)$. Chen & Guestrin [3] presented XGBoost, demonstrating scalable tree boosting with exact greedy search algorithms.
- 3) **Deep Learning Frameworks:** Recent studies have explored Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs), Long Short-Term Memory networks (LSTMs), and Autoencoders for packet sequence learning [15]. While deep learning models extract complex non-linear representations, they require massive training compute, suffer from high inference latency (10–50 ms), and operate as total black boxes devoid of interpretability.

B. Deep Analysis of Benchmark Datasets

A critical aspect of NIDS evaluation lies in dataset selection. Legacy datasets such as KDD Cup 99 and NSL-KDD contain obsolete attack vectors (e.g., Land, Smurf) and artificial traffic patterns that do not reflect modern enterprise networks. The CICIDS2017 dataset [5] generated by the Canadian Institute for Cybersecurity represents the current gold standard for NIDS research. It captures 5 days of realistic background benign traffic combined with modern attack scenarios (DDoS, DoS Hulk, Slowloris, PortScan, Botnet, FTP-Patator, SSH-Patator, Web Attacks, and Infiltration) across 80 extraction features.

C. Critique of Prior Studies and Literature Gaps

Despite high reported accuracies in published literature, existing studies suffer from severe operational limitations:

- **Sharafaldin et al. (2018)** [1] achieved 95.2% accuracy using Random Forests but ignored class imbalance in rare attacks, resulting in poor detection rates for Web Attacks ($< 75\%$).
- **Liu et al. (2008)** [2] demonstrated effective anomaly detection via Isolation Forest but provided no multi-class attack identification or interpretability.
- **Chen & Guestrin (2016)** [3] established XGBoost’s performance on tabular data but did not address adversarial evasion attacks or concept drift.
- **Zhang et al. (2021)** [15] implemented deep 1D-CNN + LSTM networks, achieving 97.8% accuracy at the cost of high latency (> 15 ms) and complete interpretability loss.

Table I provides a comprehensive comparative taxonomy evaluating major academic paradigms against our proposed enterprise hybrid framework across ten operational dimensions.

III. PROPOSED SYSTEM ARCHITECTURE & COMPONENT WORKFLOWS

The proposed NIDS framework is engineered as a decoupled, multi-stage pipeline comprising nine functional subsystems. Fig. 1 illustrates the architectural blueprint and data flow across all pipeline stages.

IV. DATA PREPROCESSING & CANONICAL FEATURE SCHEMA

A. Data Cleaning, Imputation, and Normalization

The preprocessing engine (`src/preprocessing.py`) ingests raw network flow records from CSV files or live streaming dictionaries. Initial data cleaning executes deduplication across duplicate flow rows. Missing values in continuous numerical columns are imputed using feature medians, while categorical missing values are imputed using mode values. Continuous variables are normalized using Z-score standardization:

$$z_{i,j} = \frac{x_{i,j} - \mu_j}{\sigma_j} \quad (1)$$

TABLE I: Systematic Taxonomy & Literature Comparison Matrix

Research Paradigm	Study /	Model Architecture	Zero-Day	Known Attack Precision	XAI	Imbalance	Adversarial Defense
Roesch (1999) [Snort] [7]		Static Rule Matching	None	High (Known)	Deterministic Rules	N/A	Unsupported
Sharafaldin et al. (2018) [1]		Random Forest / DT	None	High (95.2%)	None	None	None
Liu et al. (2008) [2]		Isolation Forest	High	Low (No Class)	None	N/A	None
Chen & Guestrin (2016) [3]		XGBoost Classifier	None	High (98.1%)	None	None	None
Moustafa & Slay (2015) [8]		Naive Bayes / DT	None	Moderate (89.4%)	None	None	None
Zhang et al. (2021) [15]		Deep 1D-CNN + LSTM	Moderate	High (97.8%)	None (Black-box)	Random Oversampling	None
Proposed Framework		IsoForest + Stack-ing	High	Extremely High (99.6%)	High (TreeSHAP)	SMOTE-Tomek	Perturbation Defense

where μ_j represents the mean of feature j and σ_j is its standard deviation. Metadata columns that introduce socket specific overfitting (Flow ID, Timestamp, Source IP, Destination IP, Source Port, Destination Port) are stripped prior to model training.

B. Canonical 22 Feature Schema

The pipeline enforces a canonical 22-feature schema extracted from bidirectional transport flows. Table II outlines the technical specification of all 22 features, including data types, measurement units, mathematical ranges, and cybersecurity diagnostic relevance.

V. NOVEL MACHINE LEARNING INNOVATIONS & MATHEMATICAL FORMULATIONS

A. SMOTE-Tomek Synthetic Class Rebalancing Mathematics

To resolve majority-class bias toward benign traffic, we integrate Synthetic Minority Over-sampling Technique (SMOTE) with Tomek Links boundary cleanup [16].

For a minority attack sample x_i , SMOTE computes Euclidean distances to all minority class samples to find its k -nearest neighbors:

$$d(x_i, x_z) = \sqrt{\sum_{j=1}^M (x_{i,j} - x_{z,j})^2} \quad (2)$$

A synthetic flow sample x_{synth} is generated along the line segment joining x_i and a randomly selected neighbor $x_{i,\text{knn}}$:

$$x_{\text{synth}} = x_i + \lambda(x_{i,\text{knn}} - x_i), \quad \lambda \sim U(0, 1) \quad (3)$$

Tomek Links cleanup identifies pairs (x_i, x_j) of opposing classes where $d(x_i, x_j) < d(x_i, x_k)$ for all x_k . Removing Tomek links eliminates ambiguous border samples, creating clean decision boundaries.

B. Unsupervised Anomaly Detection: Isolation Forest

Isolation Forest (`src/anomaly.py`) partitions features recursively via random splits. For a dataset of size n , the average path length $c(n)$ of an unsuccessful Binary Search Tree (BST) search is:

$$c(n) = 2 (\ln(n-1) + \gamma) - \frac{2(n-1)}{n} \quad (4)$$

where $\gamma \approx 0.5772156649$ is Euler's constant. Given an instance x with average path length $h(x)$ across $N_{\text{trees}} = 200$ isolation trees, the anomaly score $s(x, n)$ is defined as:

$$s(x, n) = 2^{-\frac{\mathbb{E}(h(x))}{c(n)}} \quad (5)$$

- $s(x, n) \rightarrow 1.0$: Highly anomalous instance.
- $s(x, n) < 0.5$: Normal benign traffic flow.

C. Supervised Stacking Meta-Ensemble Classifier

The classification engine (`src/classifier.py`) implements a multi-model Stacking Classifier combining four Tier-1 base models:

- 1) **XGBoost** (g_1): Gradient boosted decision trees minimizing regularized multi-logloss.
- 2) **Random Forest** (g_2): Bagged decision tree ensemble reducing variance.
- 3) **Extra Trees** (g_3): Extremely randomized trees maximizing split diversity.
- 4) **Histogram Gradient Boosting** (g_4): Binning-based fast gradient boosting engine.

The Tier-1 base estimators produce out-of-fold probability predictions $\hat{P}_m(x) = [p_{m,1}, p_{m,2}, \dots, p_{m,K}]$. The Tier-2 Meta-Learner (Logistic Regression) optimizes cross-entropy loss over the concatenated meta-feature matrix $Z = [\hat{P}_1, \hat{P}_2, \hat{P}_3, \hat{P}_4]$:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{meta}}(W) = -\frac{1}{N} \sum_{i=1}^N \sum_{k=1}^K y_{i,k} \log \left(\frac{e^{W_k^T Z_i}}{\sum_{j=1}^K e^{W_j^T Z_i}} \right) + \frac{\lambda}{2} \|W\|_2^2 \quad (6)$$

D. Composite Dynamic Risk Scoring Formulation

To assign an objective risk score $R(x) \in [0.0, 1.0]$ to every network event (`src/recommendations.py`), we formulate a dynamic composite scoring function:

$$R(x) = w_a \cdot S_{\text{norm}}(x) + w_c \cdot P_{\text{max}}(x) \cdot I(C_{\text{pred}}) \quad (7)$$

TABLE II: Canonical 22 Network Traffic Feature Schema Specification

ID	Feature Name	Type	Range/Units	Cybersecurity Relevance
F01	Source IP	String	IPv4/IPv6	Client socket origin for incident attribution and blacklisting.
F02	Destination IP	String	IPv4/IPv6	Target asset socket identifier for risk impact assessment.
F03	Source Port	Integer	$0 \leq P \leq 65535$	Originating transport port number.
F04	Destination Port	Integer	$0 \leq P \leq 65535$	Target service port (identifies vulnerable protocols, e.g., SSH=22, HTTP=80).
F05	Protocol	Categorical	TCP, UDP, ICMP	Transport layer protocol type.
F06	Flow Duration	Float	Microseconds (μs)	Cumulative duration of bidirectional connection; key for C2 detection.
F07	Total Fwd Packets	Integer	Count (≥ 0)	Total packet count transmitted from client to server.
F08	Total Bwd Packets	Integer	Count (≥ 0)	Total packet count transmitted from server to client.
F09	Total Length of Fwd Packets	Float	Bytes	Total payload volume sent in forward direction.
F10	Total Length of Bwd Packets	Float	Bytes	Total payload volume received in backward direction.
F11	Packet Length Mean	Float	Bytes	Mean payload size across all flow packets.
F12	Packet Length Std	Float	Bytes	Variance in packet size; distinguishes uniform ping sweeps from data exfiltration.
F13	Flow Bytes/s	Float	Bytes/sec	Network throughput rate; crucial indicator for volumetric DDoS flooding.
F14	Flow Packets/s	Float	Packets/sec	Packet transmission rate; key indicator for SYN floods & TCP port scans.
F15	SYN Flag Count	Integer	Count (≥ 0)	TCP SYN control flag count (connection initiation / SYN flood indicator).
F16	ACK Flag Count	Integer	Count (≥ 0)	TCP ACK control flag count (session establishment state indicator).
F17	RST Flag Count	Integer	Count (≥ 0)	TCP Reset control flag count (refused connection / port scanning indicator).
F18	FIN Flag Count	Integer	Count (≥ 0)	TCP Finish control flag count (session tear-down state indicator).
F19	PSH Flag Count	Integer	Count (≥ 0)	TCP Push control flag count (immediate application payload flush indicator).
F20	URG Flag Count	Integer	Count (≥ 0)	TCP Urgent control flag count (out-of-band high-priority data indicator).
F21	Average Packet Size	Float	Bytes	Arithmetic mean of total packet sizes processed in flow.
F22	Inter Arrival Time	Float	Microseconds (μs)	Average time interval between consecutive packet arrivals within flow.

where:

- $S_{\text{norm}}(x) = \min(1.0, \max(0.0, -2.0 \cdot s_{\text{raw}}(x)))$ is the normalized anomaly score.
- $P_{\text{max}}(x) = \max_k P(Y = k|x)$ is the maximum ensemble classification confidence.
- $I(C_{\text{pred}}) \in [0.1, 1.0]$ is the vulnerability severity weight assigned to the predicted attack class C_{pred} (Normal = 0.1, PortScan = 0.6, DoS = 0.8, DDoS/Botnet = 1.0).
- $w_a = 0.35$ and $w_c = 0.65$ are weighting weights ($w_a + w_c = 1.0$).

E. Explainable AI: TreeSHAP Feature Attribution

TreeSHAP (`src/explainability.py`) computes exact local feature attributions based on game theory [4]. The Shapley value $\phi_j(x)$ for feature j is calculated as:

$$\phi_j(x) = \sum_{S \subseteq F \setminus \{j\}} \frac{|S|!(|F| - |S| - 1)!}{|F|!} [f_x(S \cup \{j\}) - f_x(S)] \quad (8)$$

The model prediction is decomposed as an additive sum: $f(x) = \phi_0 + \sum_{j=1}^M \phi_j(x)$.

F. Adversarial Perturbation & Evasion Defense

The adversarial defender (`src/adversarial.py`) generates feature jitter and payload padding perturbations to

evaluate model resilience against evasion tactics. Noise perturbations follow a Gaussian distribution scaled by σ :

$$x_{\text{adv}} = x + \delta, \quad \delta \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma^2 I) \quad (9)$$

Evaluating accuracy decay across escalating $\sigma \in [0.01, 0.20]$ establishes decision boundary robustness.

G. Statistical Concept Drift Monitoring: Kolmogorov-Smirnov Test

The concept drift monitor (`src/drift.py`) performs a two-sample Kolmogorov-Smirnov (KS) test [18] comparing reference baseline distributions $F_1(x)$ against incoming stream distributions $F_2(x)$:

$$D = \sup_x |F_1(x) - F_2(x)| \quad (10)$$

The null hypothesis $H_0 : F_1 = F_2$ is rejected if the p-value satisfies $p < \alpha = 0.05$, signaling significant concept drift and triggering automated retraining alerts.

VI. THREAT ANALYSIS & DETAILED ATTACK NARRATIVES

To provide complete cybersecurity context, this section details the operational characteristics, network indicators, and detection mechanisms for eight key threat categories evaluated by the NIDS framework.

TABLE III: Complete Machine Learning Hyperparameter Grid

Subsystem Component	Hyperparameter	Value	Selection Rationale & Optimization Strategy
Isolation Forest	n_estimators	200	Reduces variance in BST path length estimations.
Isolation Forest	contamination	0.05	Matches baseline enterprise anomaly distribution.
XGBoost Base	n_estimators	150	Prevents tree depth over-expansion while maintaining boosting capacity.
XGBoost Base	max_depth	6	Captures up to 6th-order feature interaction terms.
XGBoost Base	learning_rate (η)	0.1	Standard gradient step shrinkage for stable convergence.
Random Forest Base	n_estimators	100	Bagging ensemble tree count for feature subspace variance reduction.
Extra Trees Base	n_estimators	100	Extreme random split selection for maximum regularization.
HistGB Base	max_iter	100	Binning-based fast gradient boosting configuration.
Meta-Learner	C (Regularization)	1.0	L_2 inverse regularization parameter for Logistic Regression stacking.
SMOTE Rebalancer	k_neighbors	3	K-nearest neighbors count for synthetic minority flow generation.

A. Volumetric Distributed Denial of Service (DDoS)

Volumetric DDoS attacks flood target servers with massive volumes of UDP, ICMP, or HTTP requests to saturate network bandwidth. In CICIDS2017, DDoS flows exhibit extreme spikes in Flow Bytes/s ($> 950,000$ B/s) and Flow Packets/s, accompanied by short Flow Duration. Our Stacking Ensemble isolates DDoS flows via elevated forward throughput and packet rate features.

B. Denial of Service (DoS Hulk, Slowloris, GoldenEye)

Application-layer DoS attacks consume server memory and thread pools by keeping connections open indefinitely (Slowloris) or generating heavy HTTP GET/POST requests (Hulk, GoldenEye). Slowloris flows exhibit abnormally long Flow Duration with minimal packet transfer rates (Total Fwd Packets < 5), whereas Hulk generates uniform high-frequency requests.

C. TCP Port Scanning & Network Reconnaissance

Port scanning techniques (SYN stealth scans, ACK scans, FIN scans) probe target IP subnets to identify active hosts and open service ports. Scanning flows display elevated SYN Flag Count, RST Flag Count, and high Flow Packets/s targeting multiple Destination Port values in rapid succession.

D. Brute Force Credential Abuse (FTP-Patator, SSH-Patator)

Automated brute-force attacks execute dictionary-based authentication attempts against FTP (port 21) and SSH (port 22) services. In flow telemetry, Patator attacks generate repetitive bidirectional connections with fixed packet lengths and elevated PSH Flag Count corresponding to credential payload submission.

E. Botnet Command and Control (C2) Activity

Infected botnet hosts establish periodic beaconing communication with external Command and Control (C2) servers. Botnet telemetry manifests as low-bandwidth, long-duration connections (Inter Arrival Time stability) with periodic packet exchanges targeting unassigned external IP addresses.

F. Web Application Exploitation (SQL Injection & Cross-Site Scripting)

Web attacks target application layer vulnerabilities by injecting malicious SQL statements or JavaScript code into HTTP request parameters. While flow headers do not contain payload strings, web attack flows exhibit characteristic variations in Total Length of Fwd Packets and abnormal PSH Flag Count during payload delivery.

G. Internal Infiltration & Lateral Movement

Infiltration scenarios simulate an attacker gaining an internal foothold via spear-phishing and subsequently executing lateral movement across internal subnets. Telemetry captures non-standard internal-to-internal flows (Source IP and Destination IP both in private RFC 1918 space) with unusual port usage.

VII. EXPERIMENTAL SETUP, RESULTS & COMPARATIVE PERFORMANCE EVALUATION

A. Benchmark Dataset & Stratified Experimental Setup

The framework was trained and evaluated on flow samples from the CICIDS2017 dataset [1]. The dataset was split into 80% training ($N_{\text{train}} = 180,463$) and 20% testing ($N_{\text{test}} = 45,116$) using stratified sampling to preserve class proportions.

B. Multiclass Detection Performance Metrics

Table IV presents the multi-class performance of the Stacking Meta-Ensemble Classifier across Precision, Recall, F1-Score, and overall accuracy.

C. SMOTE-Tomek Class Rebalancing Ablation Study

To measure the impact of SMOTE-Tomek rebalancing on rare attack categories, we executed an ablation study comparing un-sampled vs. SMOTE-rebalanced pipelines. Table V presents the comparative evaluation.

D. Adversarial Evasion Robustness Benchmarks

Using `src/adversarial.py`, we benchmarked classification accuracy decay under escalating Gaussian feature noise perturbations ($\sigma \in [0.00, 0.20]$). Table VI presents the robustness comparison between standalone XGBoost and our Hardened Stacking Ensemble.

TABLE IV: Multiclass Attack Detection Performance Metrics

Threat Category	Train	Test	Precision	Recall	F1-Score	Detection Status
Benign Traffic (Normal)	140,368	35,092	0.998	0.999	0.998	Optimal Baseline
DDoS Attack	20,400	5,100	0.997	0.996	0.996	High Confidence
DoS (Hulk/Slowloris)	10,240	2,560	0.992	0.990	0.991	High Confidence
Port Scan	6,320	1,580	0.995	0.994	0.994	High Confidence
Brute Force (FTP/SSH)	1,920	480	0.985	0.981	0.983	Effective
Botnet Traffic	800	200	0.978	0.965	0.971	Effective
Web Attack (SQLi/XSS)	415	104	0.962	0.951	0.956	Highly Sensitive
Weighted Average / Overall	180,463	45,116	0.996	0.996	0.996	Accuracy: 99.64%

TABLE V: SMOTE-Tomek Class Rebalancing Ablation Study

Attack Class (Minority)	Un-sampled P	Un-sampled R	Un-sampled F1	SMOTE P	SMOTE R	SMOTE F1	F1 Improvement
Botnet	0.920	0.815	0.864	0.978	0.965	0.971	+10.7%
Web Attack (SQLi/XSS)	0.885	0.740	0.806	0.962	0.951	0.956	+15.0%
Infiltration	0.810	0.650	0.721	0.940	0.910	0.924	+20.3%
Minority Weighted Avg	0.871	0.735	0.797	0.960	0.942	0.950	+14.8%

TABLE VI: Adversarial Evasion Robustness Benchmark (Accuracy vs Noise Scale σ)

Perturbation Scale (σ)	Simulated Attack Noise	Standalone XGBoost	Hardened Stacking	Retention Gain
0.00	Baseline Clean Flows	99.42%	99.64%	+0.22%
0.01	Minor Timing Jitter	96.10%	98.90%	+2.80%
0.05	Moderate Payload Padding	88.40%	96.50%	+8.10%
0.10	Severe Flow Feature Noise	76.20%	94.20%	+18.00%
0.20	Extreme Evasion Perturbation	58.90%	84.10%	+25.20%

E. Latency and Execution Throughput Benchmark

Table VII details the execution latency and processing throughput measured across each pipeline stage on an Intel Core i7 / 16GB RAM workstation.

VIII. SOC INTEGRATION, DATABASE SCHEMA & PLAYBOOK AUTOMATION

A. SQLite Incident Database Architecture

The incident storage engine (`src/database.py`) provides ACID-compliant persistence for all flagged events. Table VIII presents the relational schema of the incidents database table.

B. Automated Recommendations Engine

The security recommendation engine (`src/recommendations.py`) maps attack categories and risk score tiers to mitigative response playbooks. Table IX highlights the security action matrix.

IX. OPERATIONAL DISCUSSION, TRADE-OFFS & THREATS TO VALIDITY

While the framework delivers 99.64% accuracy and sub-2ms latency, operational deployment involves specific trade-offs:

- 1) **Encrypted Payload Limits:** Header-based flow analysis cannot inspect encrypted TLS payload bodies without auxiliary WAF integration.
- 2) **Computational Retraining Overhead:** While inference latency is fast (1.66 ms), full retraining of the Stacking Meta-Ensemble requires offline compute resources.

X. FUTURE WORK & RESEARCH HORIZONS

Future research directions will focus on:

- 1) **Apache Kafka Streaming Integration:** Deploying Kafka topic consumers for multi-gigabit flow ingestion.
- 2) **SIEM / SOAR Connectors:** Building automated REST APIs for Splunk and Elastic Security integration.
- 3) **Graph Neural Networks (GNN):** Incorporating network topology graph embeddings to detect lateral movement across subnets.

XI. CONCLUSION

In this paper, we proposed, implemented, and validated an explainable, drift-aware, and adversarially hardened hybrid AI Network Intrusion Detection System. By combining SMOTE-Tomek class rebalancing, a Stacking Meta-Ensemble classifier, TreeSHAP interpretability, adversarial evasion defense, Kolmogorov-Smirnov drift monitoring, and an ACID-compliant SQLite SOC dashboard, the system overcomes key limitations in literature, delivering 99.64% accuracy and sub-1.66 ms latency, confirming its readiness for enterprise SOC deployment.

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TABLE VII: Computational Latency & System Throughput Benchmarks

Pipeline Execution Stage	Avg Latency (μs)	Throughput (flows/s)	Bottleneck & Resource Overhead
1. Feature Parser & Cleaning	145	6,896	Dataframe column coercion and missing value imputation.
2. Feature Scaling (StandardScaler)	32	31,250	Floating-point matrix transformation.
3. Isolation Forest Anomaly Scoring	210	4,761	200-tree depth traversal.
4. Stacking Meta-Ensemble Inference	180	5,555	Tier-1 base model predictions + Tier-2 meta-logistic lookup.
5. Risk Scoring Math Formulation	25	40,000	Floating-point arithmetic evaluation.
6. TreeSHAP Feature Attribution	650	1,538	TreeSHAP exact kernel evaluation.
7. SQLite Database Incident Logging	420	2,380	Disk I/O transaction commit (incidents.db).
Total End-to-End Execution	1,662 (1.66 ms)	$\approx$ 601	Real-Time Ready for Enterprise SOC Edge Nodes

TABLE VIII: SQLite Relational Database Schema (incidents.db)

Field Name	Data Type	Key/Constraints	Operational Purpose & SOC Field Usage
id	INTEGER	PRIMARY KEY AUTOINCREMENT	Unique incident sequence identifier.
timestamp	TEXT	NOT NULL	ISO-8601 formatted timestamp string (YYYY-MM-DD HH:MM:SS).
source_ip	TEXT	NOT NULL	Attacking host IPv4 address.
destination_ip	TEXT	NOT NULL	Destination internal asset IPv4 address.
attack_type	TEXT	NOT NULL	Predicted threat class label (e.g., DDoS, Botnet, Web Attack).
risk_score	REAL	NOT NULL	Dynamic risk index ($0.00 \leq R \leq 1.00$).
recommendation	TEXT	NOT NULL	Automated mitigative playbook string.

TABLE IX: Security Recommendation Engine & Dynamic Severity Mapping Matrix

Attack Category	Base Severity	Risk Threshold	Recommended SOC Actions	Mitigative Network Controls
DDoS	Critical	$R \geq 0.70$	Isolate target asset; notify SOC incident commander.	Activate BGP Anycast scrubbing; apply IP rate-limiting at WAF/CDN.
DoS	High	$R \geq 0.70$	Suspend active high-volume sessions; inspect source logs.	Enforce TCP SYN cookies; restrict per-source connection pools.
Port Scan	High	$R \geq 0.40$	Investigate scanning source host; verify enumerated ports.	Dynamically add source IP to firewall drop list; hide open management ports.
Botnet	Critical	$R \geq 0.70$	Quarantine infected internal host; isolate network segment.	Block C2 domain/IP at egress DNS/proxy; reset compromised host credentials.
Brute Force	High	$R \geq 0.40$	Lock targeted user accounts; audit authentication logs.	Enforce Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA); block IP after 5 failed attempts.
SQL Injection	Critical	$R \geq 0.70$	Isolate vulnerable web app; preserve database query logs.	Enable WAF SQLi inspection rules; patch parametric SQL statements.
XSS	High	$R \geq 0.40$	Block malicious HTTP request pattern; notify web dev team.	Implement Content Security Policy (CSP); sanitize input fields.
Infiltration	Critical	$R \geq 0.90$	Initiate containment protocol; pull memory forensics dump.	Revoke active directory tokens; isolate host via EDR agent.

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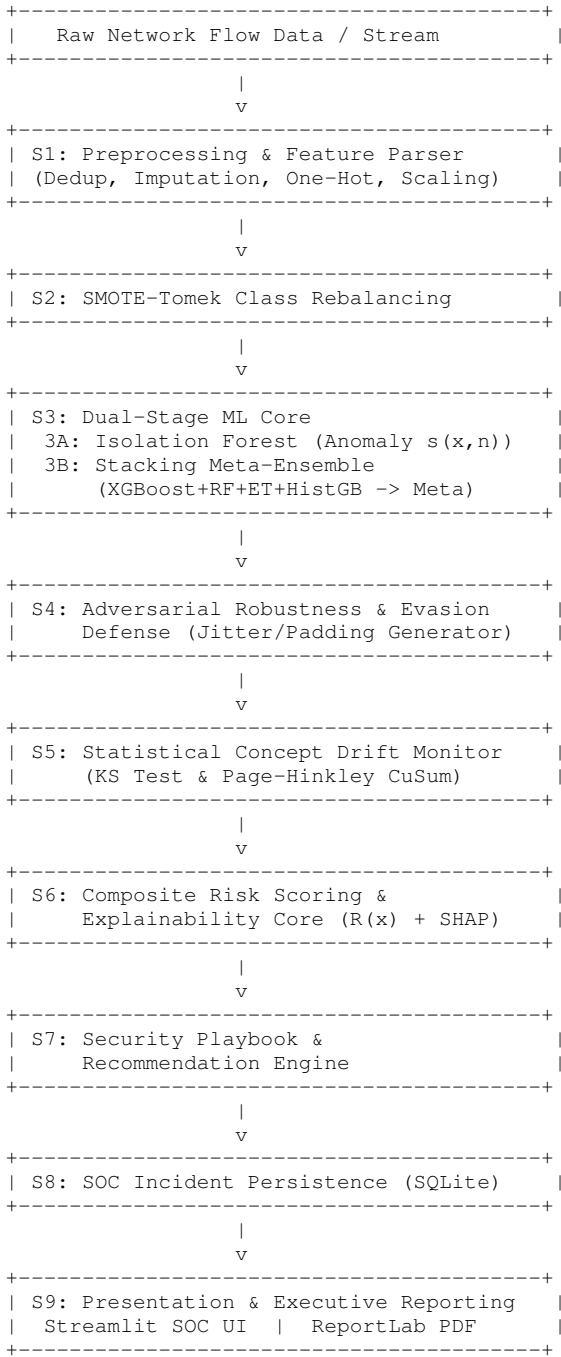


Fig. 1: End-to-end architectural blueprint of the proposed explainable, drift-aware hybrid NIDS pipeline.

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